



FAILURE TO QUALIFY FOR PARIS POSES PLENTY OF QUESTIONS

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Indian women's hockey team's hopes of qualifying for a third straight edition of the Olympics were dashed in front of the home crowd in the FIH Hockey Olympic Qualifiers, held from January 13-19 in Ranchi.

The Savita Punia-led side could only finish fourth in the eight-team event, where the top three were guaranteed a spot for Paris 2024.

India entered the tournament without three experienced players — Deep Grace Ekka (defender), Sushila Chanu (midfielder) and Vandana Katariya (forward).

While Sushila, India's captain at Rio Olympics, and Vandana missed out on making the squad due to injuries, Deep's absence was mysterious. When asked in the pre-tournament press conference, coach Janneke Schopman could only say, "Only Deep can tell why she is not here."

Still, factors such as playing at the Marang Gomke Jaipal Singh AstroTurf Stadium, the same venue where it won the Asian Champions Trophy in November last year, and being the second-highest ranked side behind Germany in the tournament were expected to give enough confidence to the side to finish in the top three. The stars had aligned.

However, it wasn't to be.

The host got off to a disastrous start as it lost 1-0 to USA in its Group